Written Off, Not Done

A free sample: the introduction and the opening of Part 1

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Introduction: The video call that explains everything

Six weeks into a search for a Data Center Operations Manager role, I got on a video call with a young recruiter who looked to be in her early twenties. Two minutes in, she asked me, straight-faced, "How are you with technology and AI? Are you comfortable using the technology?"

My resume was open on her screen the whole time. The one that listed the AI workflows I build, the automation agents I run daily, the Power BI dashboards and GIS tools and Smartsheet boards I manage for clients right now. Maybe she meant nothing by it, but what I know is what I saw: a resume that listed exactly what she was asking about, and the question being asked anyway.

Maybe it was a reflex. A recruiter early in her career, moving fast through a stack of candidates, may have seen fifty-something and quietly filed me under "needs to be checked." Or maybe she asks every candidate that question, because plenty of people overstate their tech skills on paper. I'll never know which. Age bias rarely announces itself, and that's what makes it so hard to pin down. So, I stick to what I saw (she asked, I answered) and call the rest a guess. "This might have been bias" is as far as I'll take it.

Recruiters work through a stack of candidates with a screening script to follow. The process is built for speed, and speed rewards the safe-looking choice. Most people in it are doing the job the way it was handed to them. That's the system, and this book is about getting through it.

You've felt this. Maybe not in those exact words, but you've felt the pause after you mention your graduation year, the "wow, you've done a lot" tone that means something other than admiration, the rejection email that says "we went with a candidate whose background aligns more closely" for a role you were objectively qualified for.

This is measurable, and it's documented. You didn't imagine it. AARP surveyed 1,656 workers over fifty in the summer of 2025 and found that 64% had witnessed or personally experienced age discrimination at work. Ninety-one percent of the people who'd experienced it called it common. [1] A separate 2025 AARP survey found 74% of workers fifty and older believe age is a barrier to getting hired, and 42% call it a major one. [2]

But here's the part that matters more: Knowing it's real doesn't get you a job. What gets you a job is understanding exactly where the unconscious bias lives in the process, and building a search that routes around it.

That's what this book does, part by part.

Part 1 names the problem precisely: what age discrimination actually looks like in a modern hiring process, where it hides, and what the law does and doesn't do about it. Part 2 fixes what's inside your control: your resume, your LinkedIn profile, and the story you tell about your own career. Part 3 is tactics: *the applicant tracking system (ATS)*, your network, the interview questions that never get asked directly, salary conversations, and how to know when a pivot makes more sense than another year in the same lane. Part 4 is about staying credible and sane for as long as the search takes, plus what to do with the bridge income options that keep the lights on while you land the real thing.

You won't hide who you are in this book. Your enthusiasm stays honest and your knowledge stays in plain view. The work is to stop handing a hiring manager a quick assumption and to make it easy for them to see exactly what you're worth.

One honest note before we get into it. Age bias doesn't happen off on its own. It's tangled up with AI hiring tools that barely have case law yet, a legal standard that's hard to clear even when you're right, and a labor market reshaping itself around all of it at the same time. That's a bigger fight than one book, or one job seeker, can settle. What follows is the ground-level version: what you can actually do this week, while that bigger fight keeps playing out around you.

Why listen to me on this: I wrote this after a layoff put me back in the exact job market this book describes, at the age this book is about, running the exact search laid out in these chapters. Everything here got tested on my own search first.

Let's get into it.

Before you blame age

Age bias is real, and you don't need this book to convince you. A slow search can have other causes, and treating age as the answer to every rejection sends you fixing the wrong thing. Before you rewrite your resume for the fourth time, figure out where the process is actually breaking.

Three words people use like they mean the same thing. They don't.

- Ageism is the broad prejudice; the stereotypes people carry about older workers.
- Age bias is ageism showing up in one specific decision, a resume set aside, an interview score marked down, usually without anyone consciously deciding to discriminate.
- Age discrimination is the legal term. It only counts when a decision crosses a specific line, like the Age Discrimination in Employment Act (ADEA), and someone could actually prove it in court.

Here's the part that matters: Almost everything in this book is age bias, not age discrimination. It's real, it's damaging, and it's almost never something you could win a lawsuit over. Every time you see "age discrimination" in this book, I mean the legal kind. Most of it is in Chapter 3.

Here's a quick map of where a search usually breaks and which chapter fixes it. Read Part 1 first, then come back to it when you're ready to start fixing things.

What's happening	What it probably means	What to do about it
Almost no call backs	Your resume, LinkedIn, or targeting isn't getting you found, or the lane has fewer openings than it used to	Run the age-signal audit (Chapter 4), rebuild your LinkedIn (Chapter 5), check whether the lane is shrinking (Chapter 12)
You get a first screen, then silence	Something in that first conversation isn't landing, not your paper	Rework your "tell me about yourself" answer (Chapter 7), rerun the rejection audit (Chapter 1)
You interview well, then lose before a second round	Could be the room, a stronger candidate, or bias; run the pattern before you assume	Chapter 10's script bank, a mock interview using Toolkit J
You reach final rounds and still lose	Compensation, references, an internal candidate, or sometimes bias; compare the pattern across more than one employer before deciding which	Chapter 11 on salary, Chapter 10 on interviewing, keep tracking the pattern
You're strong in your old industry and striking out in a new one	The pivot story isn't landing, not that you're unqualified	Chapter 12, and a one-page transferable-skills proof a recruiter can actually follow
Recruiters reach out, then go quiet	Could be the role, the level, the budget, or plain noise; don't read silence as a verdict on you	Verify the role is real (Toolkit G), ask about scope and range early

Toolkit H at the back of the book turns this same diagnosis into a decision tree. The tree also feeds the 90-day plan in Chapter 15. Diagnose first. Reposition second. Rewrite last. If the pattern says the lane is shrinking, change the lane, not the font.

Where are you in this, exactly

Over fifty isn't one experience. Three different fights are hiding under that label, and they call for different moves. Your goals and your finances should pick your lane, more than your birth year. People land in each of these at fifty-two and at sixty-four.

Same seat, same scale: You want the kind of full-time role you've always had. The full playbook applies to you as written.

Full time, on different terms: You want to keep working full time, but a lateral move, a smaller company, or a different industry might fit better than another run at the same title. Read Chapter 12 and Chapter 14 earlier than the page order suggests.

Something other than full time: fractional work, consulting, board work, or a phased step-down, because that's what you want or what your numbers support. Toolkit K walks through how to price it out. It's a real option at any age, and it's never a consolation prize.

Wherever you land, the fixes in Part 2 and the tactics in Part 3 still apply. This just tells you which finish line you're actually running toward.

Part 1: Name the problem

Chapter 1: It's not your resume, it's a filter you can't see

You've probably rewritten your resume three or four times this year. Different formats, different summaries, different keywords. And you're still not converting applications into interviews at the rate you should be, given what's actually on the page.

Before you touch the resume again, sit with this possibility: The document might not be the problem. The filter deciding whether anyone reads it carefully might be.

Here's how the polite wording works. People in a hiring process rarely say "we're worried you're too old." That would be illegal and they know it. Instead, you get language that sounds like a business judgment. Often it is one. Sometimes it's covering for an assumption the person may not even know they're making. From the outside, you usually can't tell which.

"Overqualified" often means: We think you'll cost too much, get bored, or leave the moment something better comes along. Sometimes that's a real concern. Just as often, it's a polite word for "we assumed someone your age wants more money and less direction than we're offering."

"Not quite the culture fit" can mean a hundred honest things. It can also mean the team is mostly young, and something about you read as "not one of us." Maybe your vocabulary. Maybe your energy in the room.

"We went with a candidate whose background aligns more closely" is the rejection email's favorite non-answer. It tells you nothing about what actually happened. Usually that's a template and a legal department talking. Sometimes there really was a closer match.

None of this means every rejection is age discrimination. You've had rejections that were about fit, budget, timing, or a stronger candidate. That's normal and it happens to job seekers of every age. The problem is when age bias hides inside a rejection you can't distinguish from a legitimate one, because the language looks the same either way.

When you read a rejection, sort it into one of three buckets:

- A legitimate business decision: budget, timing, an internal candidate, someone stronger.
- Age bias: an assumption about your age that shaped the decision, often without anyone meaning it to.
- Age discrimination: a decision made because of your age, which the law covers and which you'd need evidence to prove.

Most of the time you won't know which bucket you're in, and that's fine. The audit later in this chapter looks for patterns across many rejections, which tells you far more than any single one.

This is where the data gets useful. A National Bureau of Economic Research (NBER) study looked at real hiring at a U.S. restaurant chain, where applicants were reviewed with their age visible. After the researchers controlled for other differences, applicants forty and older received job offers at a rate 9.6 percentage points lower than younger applicants, against a 14.1% offer rate for the younger group. That's a 68.1% drop, almost seven in ten fewer offers. It was hourly restaurant work, so don't map the numbers one to one onto a senior role. T*he pattern is the point. [3]* (Chapter 10 breaks down who gets hit hardest.)

The same study found something sharper in the chain's online applications, which were screened in two stages. At the online screening stage, when age wasn't visible, older and younger applicants were selected for interviews at almost identical rates. The meaningful gap appeared later: *Once the in-person interview happened* and age became visible in a face or a voice, the offer rate for older applicants was 12.8 percentage points lower, a 42.8% relative decline from the 30% baseline rate for younger interviewees. [3]

For many experienced applicants, the interview is where age-related assumptions become more visible than they are at the resume stage. That doesn't mean every late-stage rejection is bias. It means your interview strategy needs to make your relevance, adaptability, and motivation unmistakable, which is exactly what Chapter 10 is built to do.

That single finding should change how you think about your search. Much of the fix sits in the fifteen minutes after someone sees you, so work on that as hard as you work on the document.

What happens on the other side of the desk. I've been the hiring manager a few times, in my last role at a major pipeline company, and years earlier in other roles. I've seen this process from the inside, and it's messier than it looks from the applicant's chair.

A typical hire goes through several hands. A recruiter screens applicants against the must-haves. The hiring manager reviews the shortlist. A panel interviews. HR and finance sign off on the pay. Then someone makes the final call, sometimes weeks later, sometimes after the business has changed its mind about what it needs. A strong candidate can lose at any one of those steps without anyone doing anything wrong.

Internal candidates are the ones you'll rarely be told about. At my last company, we posted a role, collected resumes, reviewed them, and hired internally. Did we know going in that the internal candidate would probably get it? Kind of, yes. They already knew the culture. They'd skip most of the onboarding an outside hire needs. And they came with a couple of years on our systems and procedures. An outside candidate had to be clearly better to beat that, and "clearly better" is hard to prove on paper.

Referrals are the other one. I sat on an interview panel once where the candidates were so strong we ran two elimination rounds. The person we picked in the end was an internal referral. They earned it in the rounds, but the referral helped, because it came with something a resume can't give you: Someone we trusted had already worked with this person and could tell us how they handled pressure and people. That's the same advantage Chapter 9 helps you put on your side.

And sometimes the process just breaks. After a recruiter screen and a first video call for *an EPC (engineering, procurement, and construction) infrastructure field deployment role*, I was sent a scenario-based assessment. The scenario was an internal global software deployment, complete with user acceptance calculations and rollouts across different regions. I've never worked in software deployment, let alone run user acceptance numbers and expectations. I filled it out as well as I could and emailed the recruiter to flag that the scenario didn't match the role.

About three hours later I got the answer: failed, and I couldn't reapply for six months. When I pushed back on the scenario, she told me, pretty curtly, that she doesn't write the assessments. Was that age bias? I have no evidence it was. What I saw was a mismatched test not owned by anyone, and a rule that locked me out because of it. A lot of what feels personal in a search is a broken process with no one steering it. Flag it once, in writing, and put your energy into the next role.

You'll read everywhere that replying to a rejection email keeps the door open. I tried it. I thanked them for their time and for being upfront, said I was disappointed, and asked how I could strengthen my candidacy for future openings. I also told them I'd love to stay in touch if another suitable role opened up.

I sent a lot of these. Only one company replied.

Send yours if it makes you feel better. Just don't expect an answer.

If you keep losing at the final round, an internal candidate, a referral, or a shifting business need is at least as likely an explanation as your age. The audit below helps you tell the difference.

Exercise: Audit your last ten rejections

Pull up your last ten "no" responses, or the ten most recent applications that went silent after thirty days. For each one, write down:

1. The exact language used, if any was given.
2. Whether you got an interview, and if so, how many rounds before the rejection.
3. Whether the rejection came before or after a live conversation.

You're looking for a pattern, not a verdict on any single rejection. If most of your "no's" come after you've been seen or heard, and almost none of your resumes get filtered out cold, that tells you something specific: Your paper is working. Your search strategy from here needs to focus on what happens in the room. Chapters 4 through 7 fix the paper anyway, because it still matters. Chapters *9 through 11* fix the room.

Composite example, not a real reader: A fifty-seven-year-old HR leader laid off in a corporate restructuring ran this exact audit on her last ten rejections. Eight of the ten had gone silent right after a first-round phone screen, before any in-person or video interview. That told her something specific: Her resume was clearing the door. Something in that first conversation wasn't landing. She spent the next month rewriting her opening answer to "tell me about yourself" instead of rewriting her resume again, and her interview-to-second-round rate roughly doubled over her next dozen applications.

This exercise stings. Looking at your rejections on paper is a gut punch. Do it anyway, then close the laptop and go do something that has nothing to do with the search.

That's the sample. Here's where the rest of the book picks up.

Fifteen chapters. Thirteen ready-to-use toolkits. Every statistic named, dated, and sourced.

Coming to Amazon Kindle on November 16, 2026, for $9.99. Watch writtenoffnotdone.store for the launch.